customary practices is undercut or alleviated by this espousal of tolerance, this idealization of a public concord as the essence of dhamma. And, as in the other edicts, the emperor highlights how he intends his administration to realize this end. Apart from the dharma-mahamatras, mahamatras who superintended what are described as matters relating to women (probably of the royal household and harem), and officers in charge of the king's cattle and pastures, are said to have been roped in for such duties.

In the thirteenth edict the emperor is at his most poignant, finally finding the inner strength to speak about the life-changing episode at Kalinga. This is where he exposes the destructive consequences of his military victory and pronounces himself the chief villain of the carnage. It is here that he draws attention with great detail to the horror and repentance it aroused in him in order to convince his listeners about the importance of self-realization. The composer of the edict says the people of Kalinga ('Kalingya') were successfully conquered by the king in the eighth year following his coronation. The graphic accompanying details need not be repeated here. What is significant is how from that painful past Ashoka moves to the present, appealing to a group of his adversaries to follow his example. These were forest dwellers ('Atavi') who he hoped would repent, as he had, so that they would not be killed. Kalinga had been pacified by force and the Atavikas may well have been the next in line: '(It is hereby) explained (to them) that, in spite of his repentance, the Beloved of the Gods possesses power (enough to punish them for their crimes), so that they should turn (from evil ways) and would not be killed (for their crimes).'[40] The threat provides a glimpse, inadvertent perhaps, of the realities of ruling a large empire in which powerful groups had the capacity to undermine the ruling monarch's hegemonic effort. Ashoka was also implicitly outlining here the limits to his philosophy of tolerance: for all his pacific Buddhism, the resort to war and pacification was not ruled out. Groups in large forested tracts were found especially difficult to deal with by monarchs at this time. The